



PC Toys

Toys R us

If building an in-car GPS navigation system hands-on is your kind of thing, this is a book that will keep you busy for a while. PC Toys shows you how to turn a PC into a toy-train controller, a home-surveillance station, or a watchful assistant that switches on the coffee-maker when it senses that you're awake in the morning. Some of the workshop topics do not involve much hardware fiddling, and a few are a little too simple to be covered in a book like this, but the overall selection is pretty interesting.

The 14 workshops discussed come with complete parts lists, and instructions on how to put it all together with hardware and software. The authors assume familiarity with PC construction, so they don't get into the details of how

you should go about installing the hardware or software, but focus instead on how to put it to use. The workshops are written in simple straightforward language and are backed up with reasons and alternative approaches, where appropriate. The bundled CD-ROM contains at least trial versions of most of the software used in the book, as well as a PDF copy of the book itself.

The basic PC that these projects need is fairly low on specifications, ranging from 350 MHz upwards, so you could implement most of these projects pretty much

using any PC. However, while it's hard to beat the 'cool'-ness of topics such as 'Create and Control Your Own Robots' or

'Build A Telescope Tracking Station', it's equally hard to find the appropriate gear to get from scratch to a toy station. Since the book is inevitably US-centric, the generously sprinkled Web links for component-sourcing lead to Web sites that are mostly only useful to gawk at.

If you can get past that barrier, this is a well-put together book that promises many days of merry tinkering!



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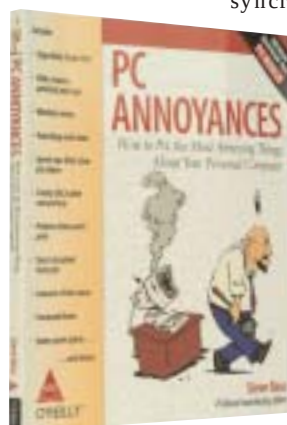


PC Annoyances

Get smart

Written by PC World's contributing editor, Steve Bass, this book is an informative volume, packed with smart tips and workarounds for those niggling problems you've stoically borne; perhaps because they sounded too silly. Sadly, it forgets to keep in mind the global user, and focuses on American users.

The book is peppered with hilarious toons across its seven sections. The e-mail section is the first, and bears tips to help you fight spam as well as tweak your favourite e-mail clients such as Outlook Express and Eudora, Hotmail and a (redundant for Indians) section on America Online (AOL).



Next up are Windows XP tweaks that should get rid of a few Redmond idiosyncrasies. The Internet section that follows has smart ideas on making sense of your bookmarks, and using Google. Here, the Instant Messenger (IM) sections could have elaborated on MSN, with less emphasis on AOL Instant Messenger (AIM). The Office section has its share of a healthy set of tips for Word, Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook and Outlook Express. Another gem is the section on Windows Explorer, which is highly recommended for anyone new to Windows XP.

The sixth section deals with music,

videos and CDs, and has tips put a first-timer at ease. Finally, the hardware covers tips on DSL and cable modems, LCD displays and printers, among others. The tips come richly-illustrated by captioned screenshots, and the language is light and witty, making for a relaxed read.

Perhaps its greatest feature are the tip-by-tip software utilities that can be downloaded from the company Web site (www.oreilly.com). It's a book with some hidden gems for the advanced user, but is more oriented at those who've been frustrated and let down by technical support. Just one grouse, though—for the price at which it retails, all the software should have been bundled into an accompanying CD. Without that, it's recommended for novices who've just wet their feet and burnt their fingers, or anyone who didn't have someone to turn to.

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